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REVIEW

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Exploring the influence of user-generated content on alcohol-related attitudes and behaviours among young people: A systematic review

Alessandro Crocetti[1] | Nichole Lister[1] | Jennifer Browne[1] | Florentine Martino[1] | Kathryn Backholer[1] | Benjamin Riordan[2] | Peter Miller[3] | Matthew Dunn[4]

[1]Institute for Health Transformation, Global Centre for Preventive Health and Nutrition, School of Health and Social Development, Faculty of Health, Deakin University, Geelong, Victoria, Australia

[2]Centre for Alcohol Policy Research, La Trobe University, Melbourne, Victoria, Australia

[3]School of Psychology, Deakin University, Geelong, Victoria, Australia

[4]Institute for Health Transformation, School of Health and Social Development, Faculty of Health, Deakin University, Burwood, Victoria, Australia

Correspondence
Matthew Dunn, Institute for Health Transformation, School of Health and Social Development, Faculty of Health, Deakin University, 221 Burwood Highway, Burwood, VIC 3125, Australia.
Email: m.dunn@deakin.edu.au

Abstract

Background and aims: Alcohol-related content on social media, particularly user-generated content (UGC), is an increasingly normal feature of young people's digital lives and has been linked to increased alcohol use; however, a critical gap remains in understanding how different subgroups of young people are exposed to and engage with such content, and how this may be associated with their alcohol-related attitudes and behaviours. This systematic review aimed to synthesise evidence on the association between alcohol-related UGC and young people's alcohol-related attitudes and behaviours, and to describe patterns of exposure and engagement within subgroups of adolescents and young adults.

Methods: A systematic search was conducted in September 2023 and again in February 2026 across MEDLINE, PsycINFO, SocINDEX, EMBASE and CINAHL. Eligible peer-reviewed quantitative (cross-sectional and longitudinal), qualitative and mixed-methods studies described alcohol-related UGC (including influencer content); explored social media use; examined associations with alcohol-related attitudes, behaviours or harms; and focused on adolescents or young adults. A narrative synthesis was undertaken. This review was conducted in accordance with PRISMA guidelines, and quality assessment was conducted.

Results: Forty-six studies met the inclusion criteria (24 cross-sectional, 14 longitudinal, seven qualitative, one mixed methods), with quantitative studies including 44 219 participants. Overall study quality was moderate, with limitations in sampling and non-response reporting. Among the quantitative studies examining alcohol-related UGC and behavioural outcomes (including alcohol use and intentions), most (n = 28/29) reported positive associations. These were observed across passive exposure, active engagement and combined measures, as well as across self, peer and influencer generated content. Subgroup findings (n = 22) indicated that associations varied across populations and contexts: adolescents, particularly those under 16, appeared more responsive to peer-generated content via

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social norms and online identity, while young adults in university settings were influenced by social and institutional contexts, including influencer content. Additional variation was observed among heavy social media users, non-drinkers and sex subgroups.

Conclusions: Exposure to alcohol-related user-generated content on social media (including peer and influencer generated content) and engagement with self-generated content appear to be associated with alcohol use among young people, with largely consistent findings observed across studies. Subgroup findings suggest these associations may vary across contexts and populations, particularly among younger adolescents, young adult university students, heavy social media users, non-drinkers and sex subgroups.

KEYWORDS
adolescents, alcohol, social media, systematic review, user-generated content, young adults

INTRODUCTION

Alcohol consumption remains a significant global health issue, contributing to 2.6 million deaths in 2019 [1]. Among individuals aged 10–24 years, it is the second leading risk factor for annual deaths globally [1]. Alcohol-attributable deaths encompass a wide range of health issues, including injuries, liver disease, cardiovascular conditions, infections and cancers [2]. Young people who initiate drinking at an early age are disproportionately affected by alcohol-related harms, displaying higher rates of risky behaviour as they transition into adulthood, compared with those who begin drinking later [3].

Peer influence plays a significant role in shaping young people's drinking behaviours, attitudes and beliefs [4–6]. In face-to-face contexts, this influence manifests through direct peer pressure, social modelling and pro-drinking social norms [4–6]. With of the rise of social media, the dynamics of peer influence are transitioning into the digital space [7–11]. There are 5.2 billion regular social media users and it is estimated that people spend 143 minutes per day on social media platforms [12, 13]. In 2024, 20.8 million Australians were active social media users, representing 78% of the Australian population, with an average of six different social media platforms used monthly [14]. Use is even higher among young people, with 97% of Australians aged 14–17 years reporting social media use [15]. Social media platforms, including TikTok and Instagram, have grown in popularity, particularly among children, adolescents and young adults [14, 16–18]. As social media continues to dominate young people's social interactions, its role in shaping alcohol consumption behaviours is gaining significant attention.

Several factors determine and/or moderate how young people are influenced by alcohol-related content on social media, including the intensity of their social media use and alcohol consumption. For example, high-frequency and high-duration social media use is associated with increased alcohol consumption [19, 20]. Additionally, having large peer networks, particularly those with a higher number of friends who posts alcohol-related content, is positively associated with increased alcohol consumption [21]. As such, indicators of social media use can be considered valid proxies for pathways to exposure and engagement with alcohol-related content. Across the developmental stages evidence indicates that social media and alcohol-related outcomes can differ. In early adolescence time spent on social media has been linked to later alcohol sipping and initiation, mediated in part by problematic social media use [22], whereas in older adolescence and young adulthood exposure and engagement to alcohol-related content, rather than time alone, are consistently associated with increased alcohol consumption and alcohol-related problems [7, 23]. However, the ways in which alcohol promotion via social media is experienced by different subgroups of young people, and how this relates to their alcohol-related attitudes and behaviours, have not yet been systematically described. This is, in part, hindered by much of the existing research treating adolescents and young adults as one homogenous group or focusing solely on university students, failing to account for potential variations across specific age ranges or the disproportionate impact on particular subsets of the population [23–25].

The social media environment is saturated with alcohol-related content. Social media serves as a significant platform for the commercial marketing of harmful commodities, including alcohol [26, 27]. A substantial proportion of the marketing budget for alcohol brands is allocated to social media platforms [28]. Numerous reviews consistently demonstrate that social media exposure to alcohol-related marketing increases young people's alcohol consumption, highlighting the persuasive impact of branded communications on young people [18, 27, 29]. Users of social media platforms encounter not only traditional brand advertising but also an increasing volume of alcohol-related user-generated content (UGC). Alcohol-related UGC may refer to content produced by users that features alcohol consumption, endorsements or references to drinking culture. This includes self-generated (e.g. personal drinking posts), peer-generated (e.g. posts created by friends/followers that others view or engage with) and influencer-generated (e.g. promotional posts, paid partnerships or casual references) content. This content can blur the lines between personal expression and informal promotion, potentially shaping social norms, attitudes and behaviours among peers [30, 31]. Social media influencers are particularly popular on platforms favoured by young people, such as YouTube, Instagram and TikTok [32]. Influencers frequently post about alcohol, and some have partnerships with alcohol

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brands and are paid to post about their products [33]. For example, Hendriks *et al.* found that 63.5% of influencers who young people reported following had recently posted about alcohol, with 19.5% clearly showing alcohol branding and only 6.5% disclosing any sponsorship [33]. Similarly, another study found that across analysed posts on TikTok and Instagram, 5% were assessed as disclosed promotional content, compared with 10% assessed as potential undisclosed alcohol promotion [34].

Despite the role of social media influencers, alcohol-related UGC from friends/peers is much more common. Most young people report seeing alcohol posts from their peers and to a lesser extent report posting about alcohol themselves [35]. Owing to the nature of social media, almost all these posts frame alcohol positively [36]. A 2023 review found that 92% of social media posts about alcohol were positive [36]. Therefore, alcohol-related UGC may be more influential in shaping social norms, attitudes and behaviours surrounding alcohol than traditional alcohol marketing.

Several reviews have found an association between social media use, including exposure to and engagement with alcohol-related content, and alcohol consumption among adolescents and young adults [7, 8, 23, 37]. In the most recent of these reviews, Steers *et al.* found that only one study assessed TikToK and only four assessed Snapchat [23]. The authors also assert the need for operational and standardised measures related to alcohol-related content, as most of the articles included devised their own ways to measure exposure to and engagement with alcohol-related content [23]. This lack of standardisation may obscure important distinctions between different forms of UGC, including self-generated, peer-generated and influencer-generated content. These limitations are compounded by the rapid evolution of social media platforms, such as the increasing popularity of TikTok, and the implications of the emerging efforts to restrict adolescent access to social media in some jurisdictions, including Australia [38]. Given the recency of the social media ban, up-to-date baseline evidence is needed to inform future evaluation. Together, these factors highlight the need for a systematic synthesis of recent evidence on how different types of UGC are associated with alcohol-related attitudes and behaviours among young people. Previous reviews have also highlighted the lack of subgroup analyses and the need for this to improve the generalisability of findings in this area [8, 37]. Therefore, there is also a critical gap in describing how patterns of exposure to and engagement with alcohol-related UGC are experienced by different subgroups of young people. Addressing these gaps is essential for understanding the broader impact of social media on alcohol-related attitudes and behaviours.

The current study

The aim of this review was to:

1. systematically synthesise evidence on the association between UGC and young people's alcohol-related attitudes and behaviours; and
2. describe exposure to, and engagement with, alcohol-related UGC and its association with alcohol-related attitudes and behaviours by subgroups of young people.

METHODS

Systematic review overview

This review was developed and reported in accordance with the Preferred Reporting Items for Systematic Review and Meta-Analysis (PRISMA) guidelines [39], and was pre-registered with PROSPERO (CRD42023459246).

Eligibility criteria

The inclusion criteria were peer-reviewed studies that: (i) included participants aged 10–24 years (adolescents, young adults, emerging adults, etc.), with studies retained if the majority of the population fell within this age group; (ii) examined exposure to alcohol promotion on social media via UGC, including influencer content that includes branded alcohol marketing, product placement, depictions of alcohol consumption, preparation of beverages (e.g. cocktails), party posts and hashtag competitions; (iii) reported on associations with alcohol-related attitudes, intentions or behaviours (e.g. consumption frequency/quantity, intent to drink, attitudes, expectancies, awareness or alcohol-related harms); (iv) were published in English; and (v) were published between 2013 and 2026.

The exclusion criteria were: (i) review articles, commentaries, case reports, protocols, conference proceedings and newspaper articles; (ii) alcohol-related content on platforms other than social media platforms; (iii) studies that examined social media use in the context of individual or group interventions (e.g. school-based prevention programs or behaviour change initiatives); and (iv) studies employing experimental designs (e.g. exposure to simulated or hypothetical social media content).

Search strategy and study selection

A search was conducted by N.L. in five databases (CINAHL, EMBASE, MEDLINE, PsycINFO, socIndex) in September 2023 and again in February 2026 by A.C. to identify any relevant research published since 2013. The four main categories of search terms included: (i) population; (ii) alcohol; (iii) alcohol-related behaviour, awareness, attitude, expectancies and harms; (iv) social media and user-generated content. Tables with the complete search strategy, including Medical Subject Headings (MeSH) terms, are included in Table S1. Titles and abstracts were imported to Covidence (Covidence, Melbourne, Victoria, Australia) and screened by four reviewers (N.L., F.M., J.B., A.C., B.R. and M.D.). The full text of all potentially eligible studies was retrieved and assessed by six reviewers (N.L., J.B., F.M., A.C., B.R. and

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M.D.). The final decision was made by four reviewers (N.L., A.C., B.R. and M.D.), with results compared and consensus reached. Reference tracing was conducted by A.C., and this included backward and forward citation tracking. No grey literature search was conducted (Table S2).

Data extraction

A data extraction template was developed in Microsoft Excel (Microsoft, Redmond, WA, USA). Data extraction was conducted by A.C. and N.L., with discrepancies resolved in discussion with the senior author, M.D. Details from each article included key study characteristics (author/year, setting and population, etc.), type of assessment of social media use and/or content, measured exposure to social media content, type of user-generated social media content (e.g. self-, peer- and influencer-generated content), measures used, and findings regarding alcohol use and alcohol-related behaviours and attitudes. Excerpts were directly copied and pasted from the articles to avoid errors, with extra columns used to apply the extractor's own interpretation.

Quality assessment

The Joanna Briggs Institute (JBI) critical appraisal tool for qualitative research was used for all qualitative studies [40], and the Appraisal tool for cross-sectional studies (AXIS) was used for all quantitative studies [41]. Critical appraisal was conducted independently by two reviewers (A.C. and M.D.), with one article appraised by B.R. and an additional external appraiser, as it was authored by our team [42]. The JBI tool uses a 10-point scale; scores of ≥8 were classified as high quality, 5–7 as moderate quality and ≤4 as low quality. The AXIS tool uses a 20-point scale; scores of ≥16 were classified as high quality, 12–15 as moderate quality and ≤11 as low quality. Mixed-methods studies were appraised using a single tool based on the component most relevant to the review aims. No studies were excluded based on scores. We deemed that the AXIS tool was more substantive and directly applicable to the included quantitative studies than the Newcastle–Ottawa appraisal tool, after having submitted the PROSPERO protocol.

Data synthesis

A narrative synthesis was conducted aligned with the aims of this review. This approach was selected owing to the heterogeneity in measures of alcohol-related UGC, outcome variables and analytical approaches, which precluded the data pooling required for a meta-analysis. Studies were classified according to key analytic categories, including study design, type of UGC, exposure type (passive, active, mixed), platform specificity, population characteristics and alcohol-related behavioural and attitudinal outcomes. Outcome measures were grouped into broader domains, including alcohol use and alcohol-related behaviours (e.g. consumption, frequency, intentions and alcohol-related harms), as well as attitudinal and normative constructs, and vote counting was conducted based on direction of effect. This was followed by an interpretive comparison of patterns, inconsistencies and methodological differences across studies that facilitated the identification of subgroup-specific findings within the evidence base. Further detail on how the studies were classified is provided below.

Classification of UGC, exposure and platform specificity

To support the synthesis, studies were classified according to UGC, exposure and platform specificity. In most studies, alcohol-related UGC was not explicitly defined or labelled as such by the authors. In these cases, we deduced UGC exposure and engagement based on the study descriptions of social media content and measures used, including peer- or friend-generated content, defined as: content produced by other users within similar social networks; self-generated alcohol posts; content created by participants themselves; influencer-generated alcohol posts; and content produced by users with a commercial or promotional presence (e.g. promotional posts, paid partnerships or casual references). Where studies referred to these forms of content without explicitly using the term UGC, we classified them as UGC consistent with our review aims.

Exposure to alcohol-related content was classified as passive exposure, active engagement or mixed exposure. We operationalised passive exposure as referring to viewing or encountering alcohol-related content on social media (e.g. seeing posts), while active engagement was operationalised as direct interaction with alcohol-related content, including self-posting, liking, commenting or sharing, and included both publicly shared and privately shared content. Mixed exposure was classified when both passive exposure and active engagement were included within a study as separate variables. Where studies combined these measures or only included passive exposure in the analytical model, these were classified as passive exposure. For qualitative studies, exposure type was interpreted based on how participants described their interactions with alcohol-related content (e.g. viewing vs. posting).

Alcohol UGC exposure was further classified according to platform specificity based on how alcohol-related content was measured within each study. Studies were classified as platform-specific when exposure was measured for a single explicitly defined social media platform, including studies assessing exposure on a participant's most-used platform. Platform-specific (aggregated) was the classification used for exposure measures across multiple platforms but combined into a single composite variable. Multi-platform referred to alcohol UGC exposure measured across multiple platforms where platform-specific information was retained without being collapsed into a single measure. Non-specific referred to alcohol UGC exposure measured generally across social media, or where platform-specific information was not incorporated into the exposure variable.

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RESULTS

Overview of included studies

Forty-six peer-reviewed articles published between 2014 and February 2026 met the inclusion criteria and were included in the review (Figure 1). The articles were predominantly from high-income countries in North America (USA, *n* = 20; Canada, *n* = 1), Europe (Belgium, *n* = 7; UK, *n* = 3; Norway, *n* = 2; the Netherlands, *n* = 1, and Spain, Switzerland and Italy, *n* = 1) and Oceania (Australia, *n* = 4; New Zealand, *n* = 1). A small number of studies were conducted in other settings, including Thailand (*n* = 1) and Taiwan (*n* = 1). Two studies were conducted across multiple countries (Belgium, USA; India, Australia). Twenty-four studies were cross-sectional studies [43–65], 14 were longitudinal studies [21, 24, 66–77], seven were qualitative studies [42, 78–83] and one used mixed methods [84], from which qualitative findings were primarily drawn [84]. Quantitative studies included a total of 44 219 participants, while qualitative studies included 612 participants.

Participant age ranges in the studies varied significantly; however, they could be broadly grouped by developmental age, including adolescents, young adults or mixed adolescent and young adult samples. Adolescents were defined as participants aged 19 years or younger, in accordance with the World Health Organization definition [85], and young adults were defined as those aged above 18 years, recognising an overlap at ages 18–19 years. Where age ranges spanned both groups (e.g. 13–25 years), studies were classified as mixed. Of the included studies (*n* = 46), 30 reported explicit age ranges, while in 16 studies the age range was not reported, despite specifying target age groups, and therefore developmental categories were assigned based on mean age. Based on these classifications, 18 studies included adolescent samples, 17 included young adult samples and 11 included mixed samples. Most studies recruited university student samples (*n* = 23), followed by high school students (*n* = 15) and with one study including mixed educational samples (*n* = 1). A small number had general youth samples (*n* = 6), while one study recruited emergency department patients as the participant group.

Characteristics of alcohol-related UGC and exposure

Following our classification of UGC, the included studies were broadly grouped according to the focus of the content. Most studies focused on the influence of peer and self-generated content on alcohol-related behaviours and attitudes (*n* = 25, 46%; Table 1). Fourteen studies specifically focused on peer-generated content influence on alcohol-related attitudes and behaviours (31%). Four examined peer- and influencer-generated content (10%), two focused solely on influencer-generated content (4%), and one focused on peer-, self- and influencer-generated content. One study used a composite measure that included self-generated content (posting) alongside broader forms of engagement with alcohol-related social media marketing; this was classified as self-generated content, acknowledging that it was not specific to UGC alone. [58]

Among all studies exposure to alcohol-related UGC was most commonly measured or described through passive exposure (*n* = 23, 50%). In contrast, 19 studies assessed mixed exposure (41%), where studies included separate items capturing both passive exposure and active engagement within the same study, and included an examination of associations separately, while four studies examined active engagement exclusively (9%; Table 1). Among both active and mixed-exposure studies, engagement was predominantly measured as posting or sharing alcohol-related UGC; however, most studies treated sharing as synonymous with posting. Fewer studies captured more routine interactive behaviours by participants themselves, such as liking, commenting or sharing content via reposts and private posts/stories [50, 59, 67]. Additionally, no studies examined alcohol-related UGC by specific beverage type (e.g. beer, spirits, wine or cocktails).

Across all exposure types and studies, measures were predominantly non-specific to the platform (*n* = 33; 72%). Among studies incorporating platform-level data, exposure was more commonly combined into a single composite variable (platform-specific aggregated or most used; *n* = 6), followed by platform-specific (*n* = 5) and then multi-platform (n = 2). Where platforms were specified and not aggregated, Facebook (*n* = 3) and Instagram and Snapchat (*n* = 2) were most commonly examined, followed by individual studies examining Instagram only, Snapchat only, and a multi-platform combination of Facebook, YouTube and Twitter. One study examined platform-specific associations with alcohol-related behaviours in preliminary or bivariate analyses [73]; however, these distinctions were not retained in multi-variate models, where exposure was operationalised as a composite across platforms.

Quality assessment

Most quantitative studies were assessed as moderate quality (*n* = 31), with four rated as high quality and three rated as low quality (Table 2). The most common shortcomings were the lack of sample size justification, unclear or inappropriate sampling frames, insufficient detail on selection processes to demonstrate representativeness, and limited attention to non-responders. Few studies reported measures to address or categorise non-response, and information on non-responders was generally absent. For the JBI qualitative assessment, most studies were rated as moderate quality (*n* = 5), while two were rated as high and low quality, respectively (Table 3). The main limitations in the qualitative studies were the absence of discussion on researcher influence and the lack of a positionality statement.

Impact of alcohol-related UGC on alcohol consumption behaviours (aim 1)

Of the 29 quantitative studies examining exposure to alcohol-related UGC, specifically peer- and/or influencer-generated content and alcohol consumption behaviours including alcohol use and drinking intentions, most (*n* = 28) reported a positive association between

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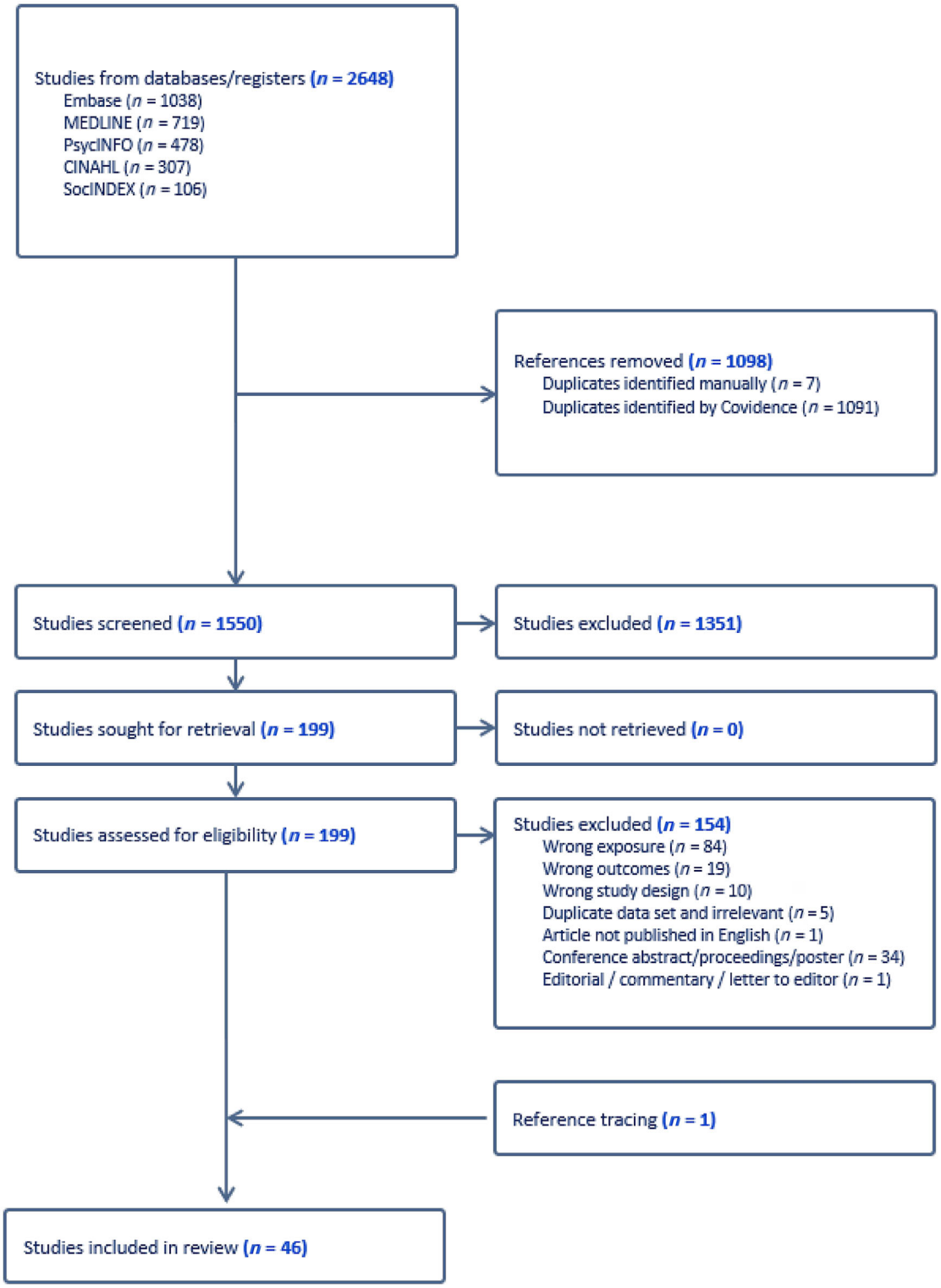


FIGURE 1 Preferred Reporting Items for Systematic reviews and Meta-Analyses (PRISMA) flow chart of included and excluded studies

exposure and alcohol use [11, 21, 24, 46, 48–55, 57, 58, 60, 61, 63, 65, 66, 68, 70–74, 76, 77]. Among quantitative studies examining both mixed exposure through peer-generated content and active engagement (i.e. posting or sharing self-generated content), 12 studies reported positive associations with alcohol use for both these measures [11, 48, 50–53, 55, 61, 66, 71, 77, 86]. Among studies focusing on passive exposure alone and alcohol use, 14 reported positive associations with exposure to peer-generated content and alcohol use [21, 24, 46, 49, 57, 58, 60, 63–65, 68, 70, 72–74]. All four studies that assessed active engagement (specifically only posting/sharing

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TABLE 1 Overview of studies.

Study	Country	Study design/data collection	Population	Sample *n*; age, mean (years); sex	UGC type	Exposure type/platform specificity
Alhabash *et al.* 2021 [43]	USA	Cross-sectional/survey	General youth	*n* = 525; 18–20, M = 18.91; 50% female	Peer- and self-generated content	Active engagement; platform-specific (most used)
Barbieri *et al.* 2018 [62]	Italy	Cross-sectional/survey	Emergency department patients	*n* = 225; 15–20, M = N. S; 16% female	Peer- and self-generated content	Active engagement; non-specific
Beullens & Vandenbosch 2015 [44]	Belgium	Cross-sectional/survey	High school students	*n* = 674; 13–16, M = 14.8; 62% female	Peer-generated content	Passive exposure; platform-specific (Facebook)
Boyle *et al.* 2016 [73]	USA	Longitudinal/survey (2-wave)	University students	*n* = 412; N. S, M = 18.10; 64% female	Peer-generated content	Passive exposure; platform-specific (aggregated)
Boyle *et al.* 2018 [45]	USA	Cross-sectional/survey	University students	*n* = 296; N.S., M = 18.1; 62% female	Peer-generated content	Passive exposure; platform-specific (aggregated)
Brunelle & Hopley 2017 [46]	Canada	Cross-sectional/survey	University students	*n* = 174; 16–25, M = 19.03; 27% female	Peer-generated content	Passive exposure; non-specific
Corcoran *et al.* 2024 [78]	USA	Qualitative/interviews	High school students	*n* = 40; 15–18, M = N.S; 40% female	Peer- and influencer-generated content	Passive exposure; non-specific
Cristello *et al.* 2024 [75]	USA	Longitudinal/survey (2-wave)	High school students	*n* = 264; N.S., M = 14.91; 51% female	Peer- and influencer-generated content	Passive exposure; platform-specific (Instagram, Snapchat)
Critchlow *et al.* 2019 [47]	UK	Cross-sectional/survey	General youth	*n* = 3339; 11–19, M = 15; 51% female	Peer- and self-generated content	Active engagement; non-specific
Crocetti *et al.* 2025 [42]	Australia	Qualitative/interviews	General youth	*n* = 24; 16–20, M = 17.8; 78% female	Peer-, self- and influencer-generated content	Mixed exposure; non-specific
Davis *et al.* 2021 [77]	USA	Longitudinal/survey (3-wave)	University students	*n* = 320; N.S., M = 18.0; 61% female	Peer- and self-generated content	Mixed exposure; platform-specific (aggregated)
Erevik *et al.* 2017 [48]	Norway	Longitudinal/survey (2-wave)	University students	*n* = 5217; N.S., M = 25.8; 65% female	Peer- and self-generated content	Mixed exposure; non-specific
Erevik *et al.* 2018 [49]	Norway	Cross-sectional/survey	University students	*n* = 11 236; N.S., M = 24.9; 63% female	Peer-generated content	Passive exposure; non-specific
Geber *et al.* 2021 [66]	Switzerland	Longitudinal/survey (2-wave)	High school students	*n* = 673; 13–17, M = 15.1; 64% female	Peer- and self-generated content	Mixed exposure; platform-specific (aggregated)
Geusens & Beullens 2018 [50]	Belgium	Cross-sectional/survey	High school students	*n* = 3172; 18–20, M = 17.14; 49% female	Peer- and self-generated content	Mixed exposure; non-specific
Geusens *et al.* 2019 [51]	Belgium	Cross-sectional/survey	High school students	*n* = 866; 14–16, M = 14.85; 57% female	Peer- and self-generated content	Mixed exposure; non-specific
Geusens & Beullens 2019a [67]	Belgium	Longitudinal/survey (2-wave)	High school students	*n* = 1006; 16–20, M = 16.98; 49% female	Peer- and self-generated content	Mixed exposure; non-specific

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TABLE 1 (Continued)

Study	Country	Study design/data collection	Population	Sample *n*; age, mean (years); sex	UGC type	Exposure type/platform specificity
Geusens & Beullens 2019b [52]	Belgium, USA	Cross-sectional/survey	University students	*n* = 740; 18–20, M = N. S.; 76% female	Peer- and self- generated content	Mixed exposure; non-specific
Geusens & Beullens 2023 [68]	Belgium	Cross-sectional/survey	University students	*n* = 381; 17–30, M = 21.83; 75% female	Peer-generated content	Passive exposure; platform-specific (aggregated)
Gupta *et al*. 2018 [53]	India, Australia	Cross-sectional/survey	General youth	*n* = 631; 13–25, M = 20; 36% female	Peer- and self-generated content	Mixed exposure; multi-platform (Facebook, YouTube, Twitter)
Hebden *et al.* 2015 [79]	New Zealand	Qualitative/interviews	University students	*n* = 13; N.S., M = 20.8; 77% female	Peer- and self-generated content	Mixed exposure; non-specific
Hendriks *et al.* 2023 [84]	Netherlands	Mixed methods/focus group + survey	Mixed students (high school + university)	*n* = 263; 16–28, M = 18.90	Peer- and self-generated content	Mixed exposure; non-specific
Hou *et al*. 2023 [54]	Taiwan	Cross-sectional/survey	High school students	*n* = 3121; 15–18, M = N.S.; 53% female	Influencer-generated content	Passive exposure; non-specific
Huang *et al.* 2014 [69]	USA	Longitudinal/survey (2-wave)	High school students	*n* = 1719; N.S., M = 15; 50% female	Peer-generated content	Passive exposure; non-specific
Kaewpramkusol *et al*. 2019 [80]	Thailand	Qualitative/interviews	University students	*n* = 72; 20–24, M = 22.1; 47% female	Peer-generated content	Passive exposure; non-specific
LaBrie *et al.* 2021 [70]	USA	Longitudinal/survey (3-wave) +observational	University students	*n* = 309; 18–20, M = 18.1; 62% female	Peer-generated content	Passive exposure; platform-specific (Instagram)
MacArthur *et al.* 2020 [81]	UK	Qualitative/interviews	High school students	*n* = 42; 14–15, M = N.S; 58% female	Peer- and self-generated content	Mixed exposure; non-specific
Meisel *et al.* 2022 [71]	USA	Longitudinal/survey (2-wave)	High school students	*n* = 435; N.S., M = 16.9; 60% female	Peer- and self-generated content	Mixed exposure; non-specific
Merrill *et al.* 2023 [82]	USA	Qualitative/focus groups	High school students	*n* = 40; 15–19, M = 16.5; 60% female	Peer- and influencer-generated content	Mixed exposure; non-specific
Miller *et al.* 2014 [55]	Australia	Cross-sectional/survey	University students	*n* = 129; N.S., M = 21.48; 100% female	Peer- and self-generated content	Mixed exposure; platform-specific (Facebook)
Moss *et al*. 2015 [56]	UK	Cross-sectional/survey	University students	*n* = 145; 16–24, M = 20.8; 63% female	Peer- and self-generated content	Active engagement; non-specific
Nesi *et al.* 2017 [74]	USA	Longitudinal/survey (2-wave)	High school students	*n* = 658; N.S., M = 15.8; 59% female	Peer- and self-generated content	Passive exposure; non-specific
Pegg *et al*. 2018 [57]	Australia	Cross-sectional/survey	High school students	*n* = 929; 16–18, M = 17.3; 54% female	Peer-generated content	Passive exposure; non-specific
Richner *et al.* 2023 [63]	USA	Cross-sectional/survey	University students	*n* = 838; 18–29, M = 19.6; 83% female	Peer- and self-generated	Passive exposure; platform-specific (Snapchat)
Roberson *et al.* 2018 [58]	USA	Cross-sectional/survey	University students	*n* = 682; 18–22, M = 19.9; 55% female	Self-generated content	Active engagement; non-specific

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TABLE 1 (Continued)

Study	Country	Study design/data collection	Population	Sample *n*; age, mean (years); sex	UGC type	Exposure type/platform specificity
Smout *et al.* 2021 [72]	Australia	Longitudinal/survey (5-wave)	High school students	*n* = 441; 13–16, M = 13.4; 69% female	Peer-generated content	Passive exposure; non-specific
Steers *et al.* 2021 [11]	USA	Cross-sectional/survey	University students	*n* = 780; 18–29, M = 20.8; 68% female	Peer- and self-generated content	Mixed exposure; non-specific
Steers *et al.* 2024 [59]	USA	Cross-sectional/survey	University students	*n* = 454; 18–68, M = 22.04; 71% female	Influencer-generated content	Active engagement; non-specific
Strowger *et al.* 2022 [21]	USA	Cross-sectional/survey	University students	*n* = 130; N.S., M = 23.39; 82% female	Peer- and self-generated content	Mixed exposure; non-specific
Strowger *et al.* 2024a [60]	USA	Cross-sectional/survey	University students	*n* = 528; 18–25, M = 20.19; 65% female	Peer- and influencer-generated content	Passive exposure; non-specific
Strowger *et al.* 2024b [86]	USA	Longitudinal/survey (4-wave)	University students	*n* = 384; N.S., M = 20.04; 74% female	Peer- and self-generated content	Mixed exposure; non-specific
Strowger *et al.* 2024c [64]	USA	Cross-sectional/survey	University students	*n* = 994; N.S., M = 21.17; 62% female	Peer- and self-generated content	Passive exposure; non-specific
Tarriño-Concejero *et al.* 2022 [83]	Spain	Qualitative/interviews + focus groups	General youth	*n* = 118; 15–24, M = 19.36; 58% female	Peer- and self-generated content	Mixed exposure; non-specific
Vanherle *et al.* 2022 [61]	Belgium	Longitudinal/daily diary	University students	*n* = 337; 18–25, M = 20.63; 50% female	Peer- and self-generated content	Mixed exposure; non-specific
Vanherle *et al.* 2023a [24]	Belgium	Longitudinal/daily diary (2-wave)	High school students	*n* = 266; 14–17, M = 15.83; 56% female	Peer-generated content	Passive exposure; non-specific
Vanherle *et al.* 2023b [65]	Belgium	Cross-sectional/survey	General youth	*n* = 789; N.S., M = 21.46; 56% female	Peer-generated content	Passive exposure; multi-platform (Instagram, Snapchat)

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TABLE 2 Risk-of-bias assessment for cross-sectional studies.

Study	Aims and design (q1, q2)	Sample justification (q3)	Population and frame (q4, q5, q6)	Non-response handling (q7, q13, q14)	Measurement validity (q8, q9)	Statistical rigour (q10, q11)	Data quality (q12)	Results reporting (q15, q16, q17)	Limitations and funding (q18, q19)	Ethics (q20)	Score
Alhabash *et al.* 2021 [43]	Y/Y	N	Y/U/U	N/N/N	Y/U	Y/Y	Y	Y/Y/Y	Y/N	Y	13/20
Barbieri *et al.* 2018 [62]	Y/U	Y	Y/U/N	N/N/N	N	Y/Y	Y	Y/Y/Y	Y/N	N	10/20
Beullens & Vandenbosch 2015 [44]	Y/Y	N	Y/N/N	N/N/N	Y/Y	Y/Y	Y	Y/Y/Y	Y/N	Y	14/20
Boyle *et al.* 2016 [73]	Y/Y	N	Y/N	N/N/N	Y/Y	Y/Y	U	U/Y/Y	Y/N	Y	13/20
Boyle *et al.* 2018 [45]	Y/Y	N	Y/U/Y	N/N/N	Y/Y	Y/Y	Y	Y/Y/Y	Y/N	Y	15/20
Brunelle & Hopley 2017 [46]	Y/Y	N	Y/N/Y	N/U/U	Y/Y	Y/Y	Y	Y/Y/Y	Y/N	Y	13/20
Cristello *et al.* 2024 [75]	Y/Y	N	Y/U/U	N/U/N	Y/Y	Y/Y	Y	Y/Y/Y	Y/N	Y	14/20
Critchlow *et al.* 2019 [47]	Y/Y	Y	Y/Y/U	N/U/N	Y/Y	Y/Y	Y	U/Y/Y	Y/N	Y	15/20
Davis *et al.* 2021 [77]	Y/Y	N	Y/U/U	N/U/N	Y/Y	Y/Y	Y	Y/Y/Y	Y/N	U	14/20
Erevik *et al.* 2017 [48]	Y/Y	N	Y/Y/Y	N/Y/N	Y/Y	Y/Y	Y	U/Y/Y	Y/N	Y	14/20
Erevik *et al.* 2018 [49]	Y/Y	N	Y/Y/U	N/Y/N	Y/Y	Y/Y	Y	U/Y/Y	Y/N	Y	14/20
Geber *et al.* 2021 [66]	Y/Y	N	Y/N/N	N/Y/N	Y/U	Y/Y	Y	U/Y/Y	Y/N	Y	12/20
Geusens & Beullens 2018 [50]	Y/Y	N	Y/U/U	N/U/N	Y/Y	Y/Y	Y	Y/Y/Y	Y/N	Y	14/20
Geusens & Beullens 2019a [67]	Y/Y	N	Y/N/U	N/U/N	Y/Y	Y/Y	Y	Y/Y/Y	Y/N	Y	14/20
Geusens & Beullens 2019b [52]	Y/U	N	Y/N/N	N/U/N	Y/Y	Y/Y	Y	Y/Y/Y	Y/N	Y	13/20
Geusens & Beullens 2023 [68]	Y/Y	N	Y/N/N	N/U/N	Y/Y	Y/Y	Y	Y/Y/Y	Y/N	Y	14/20
Geusens *et al.* 2019 [51]	Y/Y	N	Y/Y/Y	N/U/U	Y/Y	Y/Y	Y	Y/Y/Y	Y/N	Y	16/20
Gupta *et al.* 2018 [53]	Y/Y	Y	Y/N/N	N/U/N	Y/Y	Y/Y	Y	Y/Y/Y	Y/N	Y	15/20
Hou *et al.* 2023 [54]	Y/Y	N	Y/Y/Y	N/N/Y	Y/N	Y/Y	Y	Y/Y/Y	Y/N	Y	17/20
Huang *et al.* 2014 [69]	Y/Y	N	Y/Y/Y	N/U/N	U/N	Y/Y	Y	Y/Y/Y	Y/N	Y	14/20
LaBrie *et al.* 2021 [70]	Y/Y	N	Y/N/N	U/N/Y	Y/Y	Y/Y	Y	Y/Y/Y	Y/N	Y	16/20
Meisel *et al.* 2022 [71]	Y/Y	N	Y/Y/Y	U/Y/Y	Y/Y	Y/Y	Y	Y/Y/Y	Y/N	Y	17/20
Miller *et al.* 2014 [55]	N/U	N	U/N/N	N/U/N	Y/Y	Y/Y	N	Y/Y/Y	Y/N	U	9/20
Moss *et al.* 2015 [56]	Y/Y	N	N/N/N	N/U/N	Y/Y	Y/Y	N	N	N/N	U	7/20
Nesi *et al.* 2017 [74]	Y/Y	N	Y/U/U	Y/Y/Y	Y/Y	Y/Y	N	Y/Y/Y	Y/N	Y	15/20
Pegg *et al.* 2018 [57]	Y/Y	N	Y/U/U	N/U/N	Y/Y	Y/Y	N	Y/Y/Y	Y/N	Y	13/20
Richner *et al.* 2023 [63]	Y/Y	N	Y/U/U	Y/U/Y	Y/Y	Y/Y	Y	Y/Y/Y	Y/N	Y	15/20
Roberson *et al.* 2018 [58]	Y/Y	N	Y/N/N	N/U/N	Y/Y	Y/Y	N	Y/Y/Y	Y/N	Y	13/20
Smout *et al.* 2021 [72]	Y/Y	N	Y/N/N	U/U/N	Y/Y	Y/Y	Y	Y/Y/Y	Y/N	Y	14/20
Steers *et al.* 2021 [11]	Y/Y	N	Y/N/N	N/U/N	Y/Y	Y/Y	Y	Y/Y/Y	Y/N	Y	14/20

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TABLE 2 (Continued)

Study	Aims and design (q1, q2)	Sample justification (q3)	Population and frame (q4, q5, q6)	Non-response handling (q7, q13, q14)	Measurement validity (q8, q9)	Statistical rigour (q10, q11)	Data quality (q12)	Results reporting (q15, q16, q17)	Limitations and funding (q18, q19)	Ethics (q20)	Score
Steers *et al.* 2024 [59]	Y/Y	N	Y/N/N	U/U/N	Y/Y	Y/Y	Y	Y/Y/Y	Y/N	Y	14/20
Strowger *et al.* 2022 [21]	Y/Y	N	Y/N/N	N/U/N	Y/Y	Y/Y	Y	Y/Y/Y	Y/N	Y	14/20
Strowger *et al.* 2024a [60]	Y/Y	N	Y/N/N	N/U/N	Y/Y	Y/Y	Y	Y/Y/Y	Y/N	Y	14/20
Strowger *et al.* 2024b [76]	Y/Y	N	Y/N/U	N/U/N	Y/Y	Y/Y	Y	Y/Y/Y	Y/N	Y	14/20
Vanherle *et al.* 2022 [61]	Y/Y	N	Y/N/N	N/U/N	Y/Y	Y/Y	Y	Y/Y/Y	Y/N	Y	14/20
Vanherle *et al.* 2023a [24]	Y/Y	N	Y/N/N	N/Y/Y	Y/Y	Y/Y	Y	Y/Y/Y	Y/N	Y	15/20
Vanherle *et al.* 2023b [65]	Y/Y	N	Y/U/N	N/N/N	Y/Y	Y/Y	Y	Y/Y/Y	Y/N	Y	15/20

Note: N = no; U = unclear; Y = yes.

self-generated content) exclusively reported positive associations between posting self-generated content and alcohol consumption [43, 47, 56, 62]. These findings extended to participating in online drinking games, such as 'neknomination', which was strongly associated with hazardous drinking [56, 62]. Vanherle *et al.* found that sharing alcohol-related posts was associated with an increased likelihood of participants drinking on the same day [61]. Similarly, Steers *et al.* reported a relationship between drinking and viewing alcohol-related content from others; however, the association was stronger in those who posted fewer alcohol-related posts themselves [11]. Boyle *et al.* found that exposure to peer alcohol-related UGC on Snapchat was more strongly related to drinking 6 months into college, compared with content from other platforms [73]. Vanherle *et al.* found that exposure to public Instagram features (e.g. stories and feeds) was not associated with increased alcohol use. In contrast, exposure via private peer-generated content (e.g. close friend stories) was associated with alcohol use indirectly through descriptive proximal norms [65]. For Snapchat, exposure across features (e.g. snaps, stories) was associated with alcohol use both directly and indirectly [65]. Richner *et al.* similarly reported that viewing alcohol-related Snapchat content was associated with greater alcohol consumption and consequences; however, this relationship was moderated by the trait of mindfulness, such that associations were evident only among participants with lower mindfulness and were absent among participants with moderate-to-high levels or mindfulness [63]. Additionally, controlling for self-generated alcohol content attenuated the main effects [63].

Influencer and brand-driven content

Three cross-sectional and two longitudinal studies (n = 5) examined the impact of alcohol-related posts generated by influencers [54, 58–60, 75], with four studies finding that influencer-generated content was associated with alcohol consumption among young people [54, 58–60]. Hou *et al.* emphasised that adolescents' exposure to influencer marketing was significantly associated with alcohol consumption, with males reporting greater levels of exposure to influencer marketing of alcohol than females [54]. Similarly, Steers *et al.* found that engaging (e.g. liking or commenting) on influencer or celebrity-driven content was associated with higher peaks in drinks and drinking motives, specifically coping, conformity and enhancement motives, and higher alcohol-related problems among students [59]. Strowger *et al.* reported that exposure to both actor- and other influencer-generated content was positively associated with both quantity and frequency of drinks, and was a stronger predictor of drinking than peer-generated content [60]. In contrast, Cristello *et al.* found that across Instagram and Snapchat, influencer-generated content was not associated with alcohol use, while influencers were associated with stronger descriptive norms [75]. Four exploratory studies suggested that alcohol marketing, including influencer-driven content, led to favourable attitudes to drinking in young people [59, 78, 80, 83]. However, Corcoran *et al.* and Crocetti *et al.* found that the consensus by participants was that peer UGC is more influential than influencer content on

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TABLE 3 Risk-of-bias assessment for qualitative studies.

Study	Philosophy and methods (q1, q2)	Analysis and results (q3, q4, q5)	Researcher reflexivity (q6, q7)	Participants (q8)	Ethics (q9)	Conclusions (q10)	Score
Corcoran *et al.* 2024 [78]	Y/Y	U/Y/Y	N/N	Y	Y	Y	7/10
Crocetti *et al.* 2025 [42]	Y/Y	Y/Y/Y	Y/N	Y	Y	Y	9/10
Hebden *et al.* 2015 [79]	Y/Y	Y/Y/Y	N/N	Y	Y	Y	8/10
Hendriks *et al.* 2023 [84]	U/U	Y/Y/Y	N/N	U	Y	Y	5/10
Kaewpramkusol *et al.* 2019 [80]	U/U	U/U/U	N/N	Y	Y	U	2/10
MacArthur *et al.* 2020 [81]	Y/Y	Y/Y/Y	N/N	N	Y	Y	7/10
Merrill *et al.* 2023 [82]	U/Y	Y/Y/Y	N/N	Y	Y	Y	6/10
Tarriño-Concejero *et al.* 2023 [83]	U/U	U/U/U	N/N	Y	Y	Y	3/10

Note: N = no; U = unclear; Y = yes.

alcohol-related attitudes and behaviour [42, 78], with participants expressing a high degree of scepticism over influencer-generated content [42].

Influence of alcohol-related UGC on alcohol-related attitudes and norms (aim 1)

Exposure to and engagement with alcohol-related UGC were associated with more favourable attitudes towards alcohol among participants, with seven studies reporting such associations [43, 45, 58, 67, 68, 87]. These findings were supported by five qualitative studies whereby the positive portrayal of alcohol on social media influenced perceptions of alcohol use [42, 78, 80–82]. Similarly, Hendriks *et al.* found that participants largely did not perceive drunk peer-generated content as problematic or as contributing to health consequences [84]. Perceived norms played a crucial role, with nine studies demonstrating that exposure to peer-generated content significantly influenced both descriptive norms (perceptions of how common drinking is) and injunctive norms (perceptions of social acceptability) [43, 44, 49, 50, 52, 65, 74, 75]. These norms often reinforced the perception of drinking as a socially acceptable behaviour. [43, 44, 49, 50, 74, 88].

Alhabash *et al.* found that both posting and interacting with alcohol-related UGC were associated with descriptive norms, influencing how participants perceived drinking behaviours as typical within their social circles [43]. Beullens and Vandenbosch similarly noted that exposure to alcohol-related UGC on platforms like Facebook was a significant predictor of descriptive norms but did not directly alter respondents' attitudes toward alcohol consumption [44]. Cristello *et al.* found that alcohol-related content from peers on Instagram and influencers on Snapchat significantly predicted stronger injunctive norms, which in turn predicted greater alcohol use. In contrast, although exposure to such content significantly predicted stronger descriptive norms, descriptive norms were not significantly associated with alcohol use [75]. The reinforcement of social norms through social media interactions was further emphasised by Boyle *et al.*, who found that observed social reinforcement (e.g. likes on alcohol-related posts) could lead to non-drinking students perceiving higher peer approval for risky drinking behaviours [45]. Geusens *et al.* highlighted that frequent exposure to alcohol references on social media increased the identification with being a drinker, which was directly linked to higher consumption levels [68]. Moreover, studies like those by Geusens and Beullens (2018) demonstrated that displaying alcohol-related content on social media was associated with higher alcohol abuse scores, partially mediated by changes in attitudes and social norms [50].

Description of subgroups of young people and their exposure to, and engagement with, alcohol-related UGC and its association with alcohol-related attitudes and behaviours (aim 2)

Subgroup findings

Five specific subgroups were identified in the literature demonstrating distinct patterns in relation to alcohol-related UGC. Twenty-two studies contributed to the subgroup findings, of which 13 were cross-sectional studies, seven were longitudinal studies and two were qualitative studies. These were adolescents (≤19 years) and young adults (≥18 years), with adolescent-specific findings limited to those under 18 years. Additional subgroups included sex subgroups, heavy social media users and non-drinkers (Table 4).

Adolescents (≤19 years)

Three studies had findings related to specific subgroups of adolescents, particularly those aged between 13 and 16 years, in relation to their responses to alcohol posts on social media [24, 57, 74]. In a longitudinal study, Vanherle *et al.* found that exposure to friend-focused alcohol-related UGC increased the likelihood of self-reported drinking among adolescents below the age of 16 years, but decreased it for those above the age of 16 years [24]. Adolescents who perceived higher levels of peer alcohol-related UGC were more likely to develop positive norms about alcohol consumption. Nesi *et al.* found that

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TABLE 4 Subgroup summary of findings.

Subgroup	*n*	Key findings	References
Adolescents (≤19 years)	3	• Peer (friend-focused) UGC is associated with stronger injunctive norms and later drinking initiation. • Effects vary by age, with increased drinking observed among those aged <16 years and reduced among those aged >16 years • Stronger online social identity is linked to greater susceptibility to peer alcohol UGC	[24, 57, 74]
Young adults (≥18 years)	6	• University environments reinforce alcohol norms through peer UGC • Distinct pathways emerge, with norms linked to exposure and attitudes linked to self-posting • Following influencers who share alcohol-related UGC is associated with heavier drinking, particularly where content aligns with perceived norms • Cultural context shapes whether self-generated content or peer-generated content exposure is more influential	[52, 53, 60, 61, 70, 79]
Sex-specific findings	5	• For males, exposure to alcohol-related UGC more strongly predicted later drinking • Among females, self-sharing rather than passive exposure is associated with alcohol use • Sex differences emerge across transitional periods (e.g. entry to university) • Some pathways (e.g. marketing receptivity) operate independently of attitudinal mechanism • No findings beyond binary sex categories	[42, 55, 58, 73, 77]
Heavy social media users	7	• Greater exposure to alcohol-related UGC is associated with indicators related to high social media use (more logins, networks) • Use of multiple platforms is linked to riskier drinking • Associations are stronger among younger users (aged 13 years) • Heavier Snapchat use is associated with higher perceived peer alcohol consumption	[21, 43, 47, 49, 57, 60, 72]
Non-drinkers	3	• Exposure to highly socially reinforced alcohol-related UGC is associated with more favourable drinking norms and initiation • Alcohol-related UGC is linked to shifts in drinking identity, including weakening of non-drinker identity • Discrepancies between self-identified non-drinker status and behaviour are evident • Influencer-generated content is associated with increased intentions to drink and purchase alcohol among non-drinkers	[45, 54, 68]

Note: UGC = user-generated content.

exposure to alcohol-related UGC from friends was associated with stronger pro-alcohol peer injunctive norms and predicted drinking initiation in adolescents 1 year later [74]. Similarly, Pegg *et al*. found that higher exposure to alcohol-related UGC was associated with greater alcohol use, with this association stronger in respondents reporting higher online social identity related to the perceived alcohol-related norms of their social groups [57]. Although friend-focused posts were stronger predictors of drinking behaviour, adolescents exposed to alcohol-focused content (e.g. images of alcohol without people) may also be influenced, albeit to a lesser extent [24].

Young adults (≥18 years)

Among young adults (≥18 years), most studies focused on university student populations (*n* = 23), with the university environment emerging as a key context shaping alcohol-related UGC and drinking behaviour and attitudes. In the cross-cultural comparison between American and Belgian university students, Geusens and Beullens (2019b) found that alcohol-related UGC effects were similar among both groups [52]. Descriptive and injunctive norms played a key role in explaining the exposure pathway, while attitudes were the primary driver of the self-sharing pathway [52]. This suggests that university drinking culture may be sufficiently universal that the effects of social media on drinking behaviours may also be applicable to university students globally, despite social and cultural differences in attitudes towards alcohol [52]. Similarly, in a qualitative study, Hebden *et al*. (2015) emphasised that social media platforms serve as an organising tool and source of entertainment in the regular heavy drinking habits of university students, enhancing the enjoyment and storytelling associated with it [79].

Young adults, particularly those in university who follow influencers that share more alcohol-related UGC, were more likely to engage in heavy drinking compared with those who followed influencers that shared less [60]. Strowger *et al*. (2024a) found this effect to be stronger for students who perceive such posts as aligning with social norms

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of drinking at university [60]. Exposure to alcohol-related UGC during the transition to university has also been examined. In a longitudinal study, LaBrie *et al*. found that such exposure was positively associated with drinking at the end of the first year [70]. During the COVID-19 pandemic, university students who engaged with alcohol-related posts on social media reported more frequent drinking, with the lack of traditional social settings (e.g. bars) during lockdown reported to increase solitary drinking associated with online exposure [61]. Additionally, Gupta *et al*. highlighted that cultural factors could play a role in how different types of alcohol-related UGC impacts alcohol consumption [53]. Among Australian respondents, posting one's own alcohol-related content was a stronger predictor of alcohol consumption, whereas seeing friends' alcohol-related UGC had a stronger influence on consumption behaviour for young Indian respondents [53]. These differences were attributed to varying levels of social acceptance of alcohol, with Indian participants reporting sharing less of their own alcohol-related UGC [53].

Sex-specific findings

Sex-specific findings on alcohol-related UGC and alcohol-related attitudes and behaviours were found in two longitudinal studies, two cross-sectional studies and one qualitative study [42, 55, 58, 73, 77]. In a longitudinal study, Boyle *et al*. found that although female students reported more frequent social media use and consequently greater exposure to alcohol-related UGC, it was male students for whom exposure most strongly predicted later drinking behaviour [73]. While in another longitudinal study, Davis *et al*. reported sex temporal differences in associations between peer alcohol UGC, with higher exposure linked to increased consumption among men specifically during the transition to college, whereas for women this association was observed during the first semester [77]. Miller *et al*. found that among young women, passive exposure to the alcohol-related posts of peers did not predict attitudes or alcohol use, suggesting that such content may have limited influence on consumption [55]. Instead, the self-sharing of alcohol-related images was positively associated with drinking [55]. However, this finding was based on a female-only sample. One study found that the indirect effect of marketing receptivity (e.g. self-generated alcohol content) on drinking behaviour was stronger among women than among men at university, with no evidence that this operated through permissive drinking attitudes, suggesting sex-specific mechanisms beyond attitudinal pathways [58]. One qualitative study reported on findings beyond male and female. In a qualitative study, gender-queer participants described negotiating safety and online visibility, particularly when they were visibly queer and attending non-queer spaces, which in turn reduced their likelihood of posting alcohol UGC [42]. Although two quantitative studies captured gender diversity, no analyses were conducted to examine differences for non-binary or transgender participants [21, 86].

Heavy social media users

Two cross-sectional studies found that greater exposure to peer alcohol-related UGC was associated with indicators related to high social media use, including larger social networks, more online friends and more frequent logins/checking social media [49, 60]. Other studies had particular findings relating to indicators of social media use as predictors of alcohol-related outcomes [21, 47, 72]. Strowger *et al*. found an association with exposure to peer-generated alcohol content and increased alcohol consumption but not drinking frequency or alcohol-related consequences. In contrast, the more frequent checking of social media was associated with greater alcohol-related consequences [21]. This relationship was particularly pronounced among younger participants, with Smout *et al*. finding that, at age 13 years, spending more daily hours on social media was associated with higher alcohol use, and with this relationship being stronger among 13-year-olds exposed to peer-generated alcohol content [72]. Similarly, Critchlow *et al*. found that participants using a greater number of social media platforms per week was significantly associated with higher risky drinking [47]. Additional findings highlight variation in how social media use relates to alcohol-related outcomes [43, 57]. One study found that adolescents who most heavily used Snapchat, followed by Instagram, reported higher estimates of close friends' alcohol consumption, suggesting that platform-specific patterns of use may shape perceived drinking norms [43]. In contrast, Pegg *et al*. found that adolescents with a strong online social identity and low-to-moderate social media use were more likely to consume alcohol in response to alcohol-related UGC, as they incorporated online cues into their self-concept more readily than heavy users [57].

Non-drinkers

Three cross-sectional studies reported findings relating to non-drinkers or drinking identity. According to one cross-sectional study, exposure to socially reinforced alcohol-related UGC can shape drinking attitudes and behaviours among non-drinking adolescents and young adults [45, 54, 68]. Boyle *et al*. found that students who did not drink but were exposed to alcohol-related UGC with high social reinforcement (e.g. 'likes' on alcohol posts) were more likely to develop positive norms about drinking and initiate alcohol use over time [45]. Geusens and Beullens found that exposure to alcohol-related content was associated with increased alcohol consumption, both directly and indirectly, via a stronger drinking identity and weaker non-drinking identity [68]. Notably, many respondents who identified as non-drinkers were, in fact, consuming alcohol, suggesting that seeing alcohol-related UGC can shape how young adults view themselves in relation to drinking, with some internalising these messages in a way that influences their self-identity, even if their behaviour contradicts it [68]. Hou *et al*. reported that among adolescents who did not drink or purchase alcohol, exposure to influencer-generated content promoting alcohol was independently associated with increased intentions to drink and purchase alcohol [54].

DISCUSSION

This systematic review synthesised the findings of 47 studies to examine the association of UGC on alcohol-related attitudes and

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behaviours among young people, while identifying specific subgroups that demonstrate notable patterns of exposure and engagement with alcohol-related UGC on social media. The findings reinforce previous research about the pervasive impact of social media on alcohol consumption, showing that UGC significantly positively shapes both alcohol-related attitudes and behaviours. The review demonstrates that all forms of alcohol-related UGC, including self-generated, peer-generated and influencer-generated content, function as alcohol promotion.

Several key findings of this review emphasise the significant role of alcohol-related UGC in shaping young people's alcohol attitudes and behaviours. First, adolescents were found to be particularly responsive to peer-generated content, with exposure to alcohol-related posts by friends associated with alcohol use initiation and the development of positive drinking norms. This supports the findings of previous reviews on the link between social media and alcohol use [7, 8, 37]. Consistent with findings from a previous review [37], this review found that active engagement (e.g. posting self-generated content and liking and commenting) with alcohol-related UGC posted by peers was associated with greater alcohol consumption. This suggests that alcohol-related UGC not only reflects but also amplifies social norms that normalise and encourage drinking behaviour. Engagement with alcohol-related posts, whether through likes, shares or comments, can serve to normalise drinking behaviours and foster a culture where alcohol use was seen as a socially accepted and even desirable activity [89]. This process is not unique to alcohol. Previous reviews have synthesised evidence on social media use and its link to other harmful behaviours, including gambling, vaping, smoking and substance abuse, identifying associations between social media use and these behaviours in young people [90, 91].

This review identified specific subgroups of young people who demonstrate distinct patterns of exposure and engagement with alcohol-related UGC. The limited yet significant findings on adolescents below the age of 16 years is notable. Adolescents below the age of 16 years were found to be particularly responsive to friend-focused posts, with strong associations with peer drinking norms, particularly among those with higher online social identity relating to perceived alcohol norms. These suggested differences between older and younger adolescents can be potentially explained by the differences in developmental age. For example, younger adolescents explore more risky behaviours, including alcohol drinking, and may use social media to explore alcohol-related content, whereas older adolescents may be more desensitised and less likely to seek out such content [24, 92]. Another key distinction between younger and older adolescents is the legal drinking age. While older individuals may be legally permitted to consume alcohol, including in public spaces, younger adolescents may be more likely to seek out alcohol-related content online, where exposure is not subject to the same legal restrictions [24]. Young adults, particularly university students, found that the transition into adult/university life is marked by increased alcohol consumption, with social media exposure a contributing factor. It is suggested that the university environment and peer drinking norms appear to play an important role in alcohol-related social media effects [52, 70]. Heavy social media users were identified as another subgroup with associations between greater exposure to alcohol-related UGC and indicators of high social media use, and between more frequent checking of social media and alcohol-related consequences. This finding is consistent with previous longitudinal research on alcohol consumption and duration of social media use among adolescents, whereby increased time spent on social media was associated with increased alcohol use, including binge drinking, over time [25, 93, 94].

A third finding of this review was the significant role of social media influencers in shaping young people's attitudes towards drinking. Social media platforms and influencers serve as the intermediary between the brand and the consumer [95]. Through strategic partnerships with influencers and content that emphasises glamour, fun and social acceptance, brands exploit the social nature of platforms like Instagram and TikTok to reinforce these norms. This is a clear example of how commercial interests exploit psychosocial drivers, such as peer influence and the desire for social validation, to promote alcohol consumption. The commercial strategy is to integrate alcohol into the socio-cultural fabric of digital spaces, making it not only normal but aspirational [89]. Influencer-generated content and its impact on young people is not specific to the promotion of alcohol products and its health implications. A review has highlighted numerous health concerns for adolescents from influencer-generated content, including ultra-processed food and drink promotion, addictive substance use promotion, inaccurate diagnosis and treatment advice, and the dissemination of distorted body ideals [96].

There are several policy implications arising from this review. While direct regulation of alcohol-related UGC presents legal and practical challenges, including potential conflicts with freedom of expression [97], there is a growing need for governments to consider proportionate measures to reduce young people's exposure to harmful alcohol-related content online. Social media companies and alcohol brands benefit from this engagement, either through the algorithmic amplification of popular alcohol-related posts or through strategic influencer partnerships that blur the line between commercial and personal content [31, 98]. Regulatory efforts could therefore focus on platform-level interventions, such as improving age verification systems, reducing the visibility of alcohol-related content to underage users, or requiring the clear labelling of paid or promotional alcohol content [95]. In Australia, legislation has been passed federally to prohibit users under 16 years of age from joining social media platforms because of the widespread harm to young users [99]. However, this policy was not designed to address young people's exposure to harmful digital marketing, and will not change exposure for people aged 16 years and over who, according to the findings of this review, demonstrate distinct patterns of exposure and engagement with alcohol-related UGC.

Another barrier to addressing the impact of alcohol-related UGC, specifically influencer-generated content, is the poor regulatory framework for the online marketing of alcohol. Influencer content can represent a commercial transaction, whether through direct payment, gifting or brand partnerships. A 2023 review highlighted that, globally,

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current regulatory frameworks, especially industry-led self-regulation, are inadequate in mitigating young people's exposure to alcohol marketing [100]. In Australia, for example, online alcohol marketing is predominantly self-regulated through industry-developed voluntary codes, which are insufficient, ineffective, and lack transparency and accountability [101]. The rise in influencer-driven content has heightened the need for stronger regulatory frameworks that prevent the exploitation of UGC as a backdoor to marketing to children and young people. This will first require mandating and enforcing disclosure requirements, usually through consumer law, which can be used to monitor and enforce restrictions on the commercial marketing of alcohol content online [101, 102]. It may also involve establishing independent regulatory bodies to monitor and enforce any rules and regulations related to alcohol-related content online [101]. Countries like France and Norway are notable examples in this regard, with alcohol marketing laws having led to a reduction in total alcohol consumption and the appeal of alcohol among young people, but neither of these laws address UGC [103–105].

The findings also have implications for public health practice. Harm reduction strategies may benefit from considering the differing experiences and pathways observed across subgroups in this review, including the role of peer norms in shaping adolescent responses to friend-focused alcohol content, the influence of social and institutional contexts as well as influencer-generated content during the transition to university, and differences associated with heavy social media use, gender and drinking status. Among adolescents, strategies such as alcohol-focused digital and media literacy programmes may help mitigate the influence of alcohol-related promotional content when considered alongside broader structural and regulatory responses; however, these approaches may benefit from tailoring, consistent with previous evidence indicating that effectiveness can differ by factors such as gender and prior drinking experience [106–108].

This review highlights several important directions for future research. First, echoing Steers *et al.* [23], there is a need for more operationalised and standardised measures of exposure to alcohol-related UGC. At the same time, greater conceptual specificity is needed within these categories to capture meaningful variation in content, such as differences between alcohol-focused vs. friend-focused content, and between the types of alcohol depicted (e.g. ready-to drink beverages vs. beer), with our review findings indicating that friend-focused content in particular may shape engagement and influence behaviour in distinct ways. Second, very few studies examined platform-specific dynamics and compared different platforms, limiting understanding of how features such as algorithmic curation, content formats, and engagement metrics shape alcohol-related exposure and behaviour. In the few studies that did, there were differences in associated outcomes. More comparative studies across platforms are therefore needed. Third, there was a notable lack of research examining gender and sexual minority populations, with limited qualitative evidence to suggest that social media practices and alcohol use may differ across these groups [42]. Future research should examine how UGC influences alcohol-related attitudes and behaviours across diverse populations and social contexts beyond university settings, to better inform tailored interventions and policies. Finally, evaluating the effectiveness of public health policies aimed at regulating alcohol-related content on social media remains a priority for future studies [100]. This includes further assessing whether interventions like content warnings, age-gating and influencer regulations successfully reduce alcohol consumption among young people. Some of these approaches are already in place in certain jurisdictions, but evidence suggests that they are often limited by media displacement, circumvention, weak enforcement and high levels of non-compliance [34, 109–112]. For example, the age-gating of pornography sites in the UK is susceptible to circumvention, with a substantial proportion of adolescents reporting the use or awareness of tools such as a virtual private network or Tor browser [111]. Similarly, while legal disclosure requirements for influencer marketing exist in jurisdictions such as Australia and the USA, these are often poorly monitored and enforced, and subsequently evidence suggests high levels of non-compliance [34, 109, 110]. Finally, in Australia, evaluating the impact of Australia's ban on under 16-year-olds being able to access social media will be required, particularly given preliminary reports of platform compliance issues [113].

The included studies had several limitations. Most of the included studies relied on self-reported data for social media/UGC exposure and alcohol outcomes, which may introduce bias, such as under-reporting or over-reporting owing to social desirability or recall inaccuracies. While some studies used longitudinal designs, the cross-sectional nature of many studies limits the ability to establish definitive causal relationships between exposure to alcohol-related UGC on social media and subsequent drinking behaviours. A large proportion of the studies were conducted in Western high-income countries (e.g. Australia, Belgium, USA), potentially limiting the generalisability of the findings to non-Western low- and middle-income contexts, where cultural attitudes towards alcohol and social media use may differ. These cultural differences were highlighted in the findings of Gupta *et al.*, where there are different perceptions of alcohol in Australia compared with India [53]. Across the body of evidence there was often a lack of clarity regarding the specific social media platforms examined with regards to exposure to alcohol-related content; instead, many studies seemingly focused on social media in general. Where platforms were identified, many studies report platform-specific descriptive data but operationalise exposure as a non-specific composite measure, limiting insight into platform-specific effects. Studies also predominantly focused on Facebook and Instagram, with limited in-depth exploration or analysis of newer, highly visual platforms (e.g. TikTok), which may have a different impact on alcohol-related behaviours owing to their unique content formats and user engagement styles.

This review also has some limitations. The rapidly evolving nature of social media means that findings may quickly become outdated between data collection and publication. As a grey literature search was not undertaken, it is possible that relevant articles were missed. In addition, there was a delay between the initial search (September 2023) and peer review; however, an updated search was conducted in February 2026 to capture the most recent evidence, and an additional six articles were included through this process. Finally, the

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classification of studies by type of UGC and exposure relied in some cases on interpretation and deduction because of the inconsistent terminology and measures used. While this approach enabled synthesis across a heterogeneous evidence base, it may have introduced some misclassification or reduced precision in categorisation. However, this reflects broader inconsistencies in how alcohol-related UGC is conceptualised and measured in the literature [23].

CONCLUSION

In conclusion, this systematic review highlights the role alcohol-related UGC has on shaping alcohol-related behaviours and attitudes among young people. Limited subgroup findings indicate variation across populations, particularly among younger participants, such as younger adolescents, young adults in early university, heavy social media users, non-drinkers and gender-specific subgroups. Given the pervasive nature of social media, public health laws must adapt to the digital landscape by reducing exposure to harmful alcohol-related UGC and promoting healthier online behaviours.

AUTHOR CONTRIBUTIONS

Alessandro Crocetti: Writing—original draft; methodology; writing—review and editing; formal analysis; project administration; data curation; validation. **Nichole Lister:** Conceptualization; investigation; writing—review and editing; validation. **Jennifer Browne:** Conceptualization; investigation; funding acquisition; writing—review and editing; methodology; formal analysis; validation. **Florentine Martino:** Conceptualization; investigation; funding acquisition; methodology; writing—review and editing; validation; formal analysis. **Kathryn Backholer:** Conceptualization; funding acquisition; investigation; methodology; validation; writing—review and editing. **Benjamin Riordan:** Writing—review and editing; data curation; writing—original draft. **Peter Miller:** Conceptualization; investigation; funding acquisition; writing—review and editing; methodology; validation. **Matthew Dunn:** Conceptualization; investigation; funding acquisition; writing—review and editing; supervision; project administration; methodology; validation; data curation.

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DATA AVAILABILITY STATEMENT

Data sharing not applicable to this article as no datasets were generated or analysed during the current study.

ORCID

Alessandro Crocetti https://orcid.org/0000-0001-6561-3703
Benjamin Riordan https://orcid.org/0000-0002-7805-0652
Matthew Dunn https://orcid.org/0000-0003-4615-5078

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